

HIGH JUMPERS

They had never seen the inside of even a state legislature. Now they have catapulted to the national one



MURLIDHAR MOHOL, *49* ▶

| BJP | *Pune, Maharashtra*

What that image doesn't tell you is that the man with the bullocks was also the mayor of Pune, and got it to be one of 50 Champion Cities in a 2021 global challenge. He oversaw the Metro's expansion, had a medical college set up and was praised for being hands-on during the pandemic. But the photo does exude the aroma of the village clay he's formed of: born into a native martial art ethos shaped around wrestling, he went to Kolhapur, the mecca for grapplers, to learn its finer points. One loss in a 2009 assembly poll apart, that skill has not deserted him in politics—long-time RSS/BJP youth wing incubation now blossoming into a surprise Union MoS slot. To reach it, he defeated Congress's Ravindra Dhangekar.

MAHESH KASHYAP, *48*



| BJP | *Bastar (ST), Chhattisgarh*

The core ethos of the BJP's tribal outreach is expressed fully in this victor from the most canonical of tribal constituencies. The new Bastar MP began as a sarpanch in his village near Jagdalpur but was soon cutting his teeth on the right wing's anti-conversion drive, joining the Bajrang Dal as a 21-year-old in 1996, and then the VHP and a slew of kindred organisations. Besides the promotion of Hindu culture in Bastar, this Class 10 pass with six children—wife Champa is a janpad panchayat chief—also has interests in kabaddi. He beat the Congress's Kawasi Lakhma by over 55,000 votes.

RAJPALSINH JADAV, *42*

| BJP | *Panchmahal, Gujarat*

It was a tricky poll for this partyman of 24 years from the OBC Kshatriya caste of Baraiyas: all Kshatriyas were protesting against the BJP for the comments made by Parshottam Rupala. But the two-term district panchayat member found himself alongside BJP heavyweights like Union home minister Amit Shah and state president C.R. Paatil who won with a lead of over 500,000 votes. The Godhra assembly segment is a part of this seat, where the release of Bilkis Bano's rapists had added to extreme polarisation. He beat Congress's Gulabsinh Chauhan.

